army, long seen as a melting pot and a guardian of values, and between Jews and Arabs. It is also having a coarsening effect on society, empowering harsh strains of nationalism.

The second question is about its socioeconomic survival. The Israel that is marketed to the world is a land of startups and entrepreneurs, an emerging energy powerhouse, and a world-class destination for tourists. But it is also a country of profound inequality—the worst in the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development (OECD). Israel's fastest-growing demographic, the ultra-Orthodox, often finish school without learning even the basic precepts of math and science. Beyond this, its various groups, Jewish and Arab, religious and secular, hawks and doves, have fundamentally incompatible visions of what it means to be Israeli. The country is so divided that one former Mossad chief mused openly about the possibility of civil war.

The final question, perhaps the most troubling in the short term, addresses its survival as a democracy. Israel, its leaders never tire of saying, is the only democracy in the Middle East, a country that affords its citizens vastly more political and personal freedoms than the autocratic republics and stifling monarchies that surround it. Yet the past eight years of Netanyahu's rule have been marked by a growing climate of illiberalism. Civil society is threatened, with a raft of initiatives meant to curtail the activities of left-leaning groups. The media is under pressure too. Israel has a panoply of news outlets, but a strikingly limited range of opinions, and the prime minister has used his perch to threaten and cajole critical voices. The political system is increasingly fragmented, unable to deal with profound issues of Israel's identity and its future. Two former heads of the Shin Bet, the internal security agency, have dubbed all of this a process of "incremental tyranny."

Despite the occasional diatribes in Beirut and Tehran—and the often overheated rhetoric in Jerusalem—no one seriously doubts that Israel will survive. But it is much harder to say what sort of Israel will survive, and this question has profound implications both for the country itself and for the half of world Jewry that lives outside of it.

The crisis of Zionism